

Five Habits of Consistent Espresso

Espresso extraction rewards patience and reproducibility more than any single piece of equipment. A consistent grind, a level bed, and an unhurried preinfusion remove most of the variability that beginners blame on the machine itself.

When the shot runs fast, resist the counterintuitive urge to change everything at once. Tighten the grind one step, keep the dose identical, and taste again; a single controlled adjustment tells you more than five simultaneous ones ever could.

Water chemistry matters less than forums suggest, but it is not negligible. Very hard water mutes acidity and scales the boiler, while distilled water tastes hollow and slowly corrodes brass components through mineral hunger.

Milk texturing is choreography rather than force. Stretch briefly while the surface is still cool, then bury the tip and let the vortex fold the foam back into the liquid until the pitcher reads just short of uncomfortably warm.

Finally, log everything for a fortnight. The notebook, not the tongue, reveals that Tuesday's remarkable shot followed a recalibration you had already forgotten by Thursday, and that repeatability was the ingredient you were actually missing.